

The Recovery Protocol

5 changes to your environment that let your brain actually recover - so tomorrow's hours count

1 YOUR BED

The Foundation

Bed frame with flexible wooden slats outperforms solid boards. The slats flex with your body and extend the life of your mattress. Minimum size for two people: 160×200 cm (63×79 in).

Your Mattress

Top comfort layer should follow your contours. Firmness depends on your weight: **Under 60 kg** - soft. **60-90 kg** - medium. **Over 90 kg** - firm. Try before you buy - lie down in the store for at least 10-15 minutes.

Your Pillow

Side sleeper - 10-14 cm (fills the gap between shoulder and head). **Back sleeper** - 8-10 cm. **Stomach sleeper** - 6-8 cm, or no pillow at all. The fold test: fold your pillow in half. If it stays folded - it's dead. Replace it.

Blanket and Bedding

Match your blanket to the season and room temperature. If you sleep with a partner who runs hot/cold differently - use two separate blankets. Natural fabrics only: cotton, linen, bamboo. Synthetics trap heat and moisture.

Temperature

Optimal: 18-22 C (65-72 F). Not "as cold as possible" - comfortable cool. Your body needs to drop its core temperature to fall asleep. A room that's too hot prevents this. A room that's too cold makes you tense up.

Humidity

Target: 50-60%. In winter, city apartments often drop below 30%. Dry air irritates your throat, dries out your nasal passages, and disrupts sleep. Solution: an ultrasonic humidifier.

Fresh Air

Ventilate your bedroom before sleep. If outside noise or cold prevents an open window, consider a ventilation system with filters.

LIGHT CONTROL

At Night - Total Darkness

Even small amounts of light suppress melatonin. Install blackout curtains (95%+). Cover LED standby lights with tape. If blackout curtains aren't possible - use a quality sleep mask.

In the Evening - Warm Light Only

After sunset, switch to warm light bulbs: 1700-3200K. Energy-saving bulbs at 5500K mimic daylight - your brain reads them as "noon" and stays alert. This alone can delay your sleep by 30-60 minutes.

Screens - Set and Forget

Enable Night Shift on iPhone/Mac, Night Light on Windows/Android. Set it to activate at sunset. Takes 30 seconds to configure, works every night automatically.

In the Morning - Bright Light

Open your curtains immediately. Bright morning light resets your circadian clock. In winter, consider a dawn simulator alarm clock or light therapy lamp.

SOUND CONTROL

Your brain processes sound even during sleep. "Meaningful" sounds (speech, TV, notifications) trigger alertness. "Meaningless" sounds (rain, wind, white noise) mask the meaningful ones. White noise machine or app - runs at 24-25 dB. Earplugs - wax or silicone, not foam. If your partner snores (50+ dB) - earplugs + white noise combined.

Dust mites trigger allergic reactions that disrupt sleep - congestion, sneezing, itchy eyes. Even without diagnosed allergies, reducing dust improves air quality and sleep. Remove carpets, open bookshelves, decorative pillows, stuffed animals. Remove plants (they produce CO₂ at night). Keep only: bed, two nightstands, one closed wardrobe. **Your bedroom = sleep and intimacy. Not work. Not storage. Not entertainment.**

Bedsheets

Wash at 60 C

Weekly

Replace

Every 2-3 years

Pillow

Fold test (stays folded = dead)

Monthly

Wash

3-6 months

Replace

Every 1-3 years

Mattress Protector

Wash at 60 C

Monthly

Replace

Every 2-3 years

Blanket

Air out

Monthly

Dry clean

Annually

Replace

Every 5-10 years

Mattress

Rotate 180 degrees

3-6 months

Replace

Every 7-10 years

Blackout Curtains

Wash or vacuum

3-6 months

Replace

Every 5-7 years

Bed Frame

Check slats for cracks

Annually

Replace

10+ years

- 1 **Light check.** Walk through your bedroom at night with all lights off. See any light? LED standby dots, streetlight through curtains, phone charger glow? Cover or block them.
- 2 **Temperature check.** Set your thermostat to 20 C (68 F) for tonight. If you don't have a thermostat - crack a window 15 minutes before bed.
- 3 **Phone out.** Move your phone to the other side of the room. Or better - outside the bedroom entirely. Get a simple alarm clock.

Medical disclaimer: This guide is for educational purposes only and is not medical advice. The information here is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease or condition. Consult a qualified healthcare provider before changing your sleep, diet, supplements, or routines, especially if you have a medical condition, are pregnant, or take medications. If you experience persistent insomnia, suspected sleep apnea, loud snoring with daytime sleepiness, or other concerning symptoms, see a sleep specialist or your physician. In an emergency, call 911 or your local emergency services.